Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Wendell Berry's "Vacation"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of irony in Wendell Berry's "Vacation" include

allegory,
connotation,
etymology,
denotation,
formula ("once there was a man"),
free verse,
imagery,
irony (including verbal),
metaphor,
paradox (at some level),
parallelism,
personification,
polyptoton,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant should find an observation central to the irony that informs the totality of Wendell Berry's "Vacation," perhaps either "He showed / his vacation to his camera [. . .]" (lines 6-7) or "But he / would not be in it. He would never be in it" (lines 14-15) and build from there.

The first of the speaker's observations suggests a vicarious personification of the video camera and its memory, thus the camera's experiencing the vacation and, in the future, the memories recorded not recalled, as would be human memory.

The second observation sums up the vacationer's seeming relinquishing of experiencing of the ride on the river for recording the boat on the river . . without any record in the footage of his having been on the river himself, except by the interpolation associated with a sharing of the footage with, presumably, friends: Where is the vacationer in the actual video recording?

The contestant might extend this irony a bit further by dwelling on the word *vacation*, noting that to vacate means 'to not occupy.' The verbal irony is the speaker's commentary—beginning with the poem's title—on the vacationer's not being in the experience of the boat ride itself, that he is experiencing a species of movie-making in which he is the producer, the director, and the cameraman but not even the central character; indeed, at best, he is someone on a job (making the movie) and not on a distancing-from-a-job, which is what a vacation is usually taken to be.

The young writer might recognize the presentation as either an allegory or a metaphor, in which the poet's central message is that being in nature should be a being-one-with-nature, that documenting an experience and having the experience are not one and the same.